

# Strong

How to Start, Stay, and Finish Strong

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*Unless otherwise noted, all scripture references are from the New International Version (NIV).*

*Dedicated to the Community of GateCity Buckhead,*

*and all those who helped pioneer our first year.*



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# Chapter 1: The Race Set Before Us

I had no business being in that race.

It was a triathlon at the Daytona International Speedway—swim, bike, run—and I had trained just enough in each discipline to convince myself I could finish. On the day of the race, I swam farther than I had ever swum in my life. Then I biked farther than I had ever biked in my life. Then I ran farther than I had ever run in my life. And I did all three back-to-back in a single morning.

Halfway through the bike leg, my watch died. I had been tracking my progress, counting down the miles, and suddenly the screen went dark. I had no idea how much farther I had to go.

That moment—pedaling forward with no data, no assurance, just the road ahead and the ache in my legs—is a picture of so much of life. We set out with good intentions. We count the cost, at least roughly. And then somewhere in the middle, we lose our bearings. The watch dies. The finish line disappears. And we are left with a single question: *Will I keep going?*

I kept going that day. But not because of physical toughness—I had very little of that left. I kept going because of one thing: my daughter was waiting at every transition.

She had come to watch me race. She had made a poster: *Swim, Daddy, swim. Run, Daddy, run.* And I knew that when I dragged myself out of the water, she would be standing there cheering. When I stumbled off the bike, she would be there. And when I crossed that finish line—however slowly—she would see me complete what I had started.

There was no way I could quit with her watching.

By the time I reached the final stretch—the actual racetrack where the NASCAR cars run—I was completely spent. I had swam 1.4 miles, biked 30 miles, and ran 13 miles. My body was screaming for me to stop. So I did something I'm not particularly proud of: I rested for four full minutes before that final lap, just so I could *jog* across the finish line instead of crawling.

I wanted my daughter to see me finish strong.

And afterward, when it was done—when I had crossed the line and collapsed into celebration—I ate the best Five Guys double cheeseburger I have ever tasted in my entire life.

For the joy set before me, I endured that race.

## Resolved in Your Mind

A few years earlier, I learned another lesson about finishing—this one on the second-highest mountain in Africa.

Mount Kenya rises from the equatorial plains into an arctic wasteland. You begin the climb among monkeys and giraffes; you end it scrambling across a frozen lunar landscape where the lakes are solid ice and the air is so thin your lungs burn with every breath. My friend Caleb and I decided to attempt the summit. We were joined by a missionary who committed at the last minute—he had a bad case of FOMO and didn't want to miss out.

He was even less prepared than we were.

By the final night before the summit push, all three of us were feeling the altitude sickness—headaches, nausea, exhaustion. Our friend had literally wept his way into the last camp. We gathered with our guide, a thirty-year veteran of the mountain, and asked the question that was gnawing at all of us: *Can we make it?*

I will never forget what he said.

He looked at Caleb and me and said, "You two have resolved in your mind that you're going to the top. So you'll make it." Then he glanced at our friend. "But him—he hasn't resolved yet. I don't think he'll make it."

This man was not a Christian. He was a Muslim guide who had taken hundreds of people up that mountain. But he was illustrating a profound spiritual principle: when you have set in your heart where you are going, you will find a way to get there. When you have seen the summit with the eyes of faith, you can endure the suffering required to reach it.

We woke at four in the morning. We climbed in the darkness, hands and knees across frozen rock, lungs screaming. Even our guide started vomiting—"This always happens to me," he said casually, which did not inspire confidence. But we had resolved. We had set our eyes on the top.

And we made it.

Our friend, sadly, had to turn back just before the summit. The guide's prediction proved true.

When Caleb and I reached the top, we were ecstatic. We had done it. We stood at the peak of the second-highest point in all of Africa and looked out at the vista we had been dreaming about for days.

It was completely covered in clouds.

We couldn't see a thing.

And in that moment, I was reminded how often the greatest journeys end without the clarity we expected—how the climb can be real even when the reward feels hidden. But here is what I want

you to know: in Jesus, we have a more sure promise than any mountain vista. The view that awaits you in eternity will not be obscured. The joy set before you will not disappoint. The inheritance waiting at the end of your race is real, and it is glorious, and it is worth every step of the climb.

## The Shape of a Faithful Life

This book is about running the race set before you—and finishing it well.

Every meaningful life follows a recognizable shape. It is not a formula—life is too complex for formulas—but it is a pattern, visible across Scripture and throughout history. That pattern has three movements:

*Start Strong*—beginning with the end in mind. Counting the cost before you lay the foundation. Recognizing the treasure and choosing to pay the price.

*Stay Strong*—sustaining through the messy middle. Establishing rhythms that produce joy. Drawing from the wells of living water when the road grows hard.

*Finish Strong*—completing what God has entrusted to you. Digging deep when the race is nearly done. Crossing the line with faithfulness intact.

Starting well matters. Sustaining well and staying strong matters. But finishing well often determines how the entire journey is remembered.

The king who prepared for battle but gave up before the decisive engagement is not remembered as wise—he is remembered as a coward. The builder who laid a magnificent foundation but never completed the structure becomes a mockery to everyone who passes by. And the runner who leads for twenty-five miles but collapses before the finish line does not receive the prize.

Completion carries weight.

## The Race You Are Already Running

Here is the truth that presses on us: you are already in the race.

You did not choose the era of your birth or the circumstances of your family. You did not select your temperament or your trials. But you are here, now, alive on the earth in this moment of history—and that means you are already running.

The only question is whether you will run well.

The writer of Hebrews puts it this way:

*Therefore we also, since we are surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses, let us lay aside every weight, and the sin which so easily ensnares us, and let us run with*

*endurance the race that is set before us, looking unto Jesus, the author and finisher of our faith, who for the joy that was set before Him endured the cross, despising the shame, and has sat down at the right hand of the throne of God.* —Hebrews 12:1–2 (NKJV)

Notice what this passage tells us. We are surrounded by witnesses—those who have run before us and finished their race. We are called to lay aside the weight that slows us and the sin that entangles us. We are to run with *endurance*—not a sprint, but a marathon. And we are to fix our eyes on Jesus, who Himself endured the ultimate trial *for the joy set before Him*.

Jesus did not endure the cross because it was easy. He endured it because of what lay on the other side.

And He invites us to do the same.

## The Joy Set Before You

The secret of starting strong is beginning with the end in mind—counting the cost and resolving to pay it.

The secret of staying strong is fixing your eyes on the reward—letting the joy of what awaits you fuel your endurance when everything in you wants to quit.

The secret of finishing strong is digging deep in the final stretch—returning to first love and first obedience when the pressure is greatest and the temptation to coast is most seductive.

All three require the same thing: a vision of the end that is clear enough, and glorious enough, to sustain you through everything required to reach it.

My daughter at the finish line gave me enough motivation to complete a triathlon I had no business finishing. The summit of Mount Kenya gave my friend and me enough resolve to push through altitude sickness and frozen darkness. But these are earthly prizes—temporary, fading, incomplete.

The joy set before you in Christ is eternal.

It is the joy of hearing, "Well done, good and faithful servant." It is the joy of entering into the presence of the One who loved you and gave Himself for you. It is the joy of reunion with the saints who have gone before—the great cloud of witnesses who are even now cheering you on. It is the joy of a resurrected body, a restored creation, and an inheritance that will never spoil, fade, or perish.

That joy is real. That finish line is coming. And the One who began a good work in you is faithful to complete it.

The question is whether you will run in such a way as to obtain the prize.

# What Lies Ahead

In the chapters that follow, we will explore each movement of the faithful life in depth.

We will begin by learning to start strong—counting the cost of discipleship the way Jesus taught us, and recognizing that the Kingdom of Heaven is a treasure worth selling everything to possess. We will examine what it means to begin with the end in mind, to see the finish line before we take the first step, and to resolve in our hearts that we are going all the way to the top.

Then we will explore how to stay strong—establishing rhythms of joy that sustain us through the messy middle. We will discover that spiritual strength is architecturally connected to joy, that the same delight which initiates surrender is the delight that fuels endurance. We will learn to draw from the wells of living water and to walk with God in the garden, even when the garden is Gethsemane.

Finally, we will learn to finish strong—digging deep when the race is nearly done, when the pressure is greatest and the temptation to ease up is most acute. We will look to Jesus, who endured the cross for the joy set before Him and declared from that cross the most triumphant word in human history: *Tetelestai*—"It is finished."

He finished what He started. And by His grace, so can you.

## An Invitation

Wherever you are in your journey—just beginning, deep in the middle, or approaching the final stretch—this book is for you.

If you have never counted the cost of following Christ, you will learn to see with clear eyes what He is asking and why it is worth everything you have.

If you are in the messy middle—weary, discouraged, wondering if you can keep going—you will discover the joy that sustains endurance and the rhythms that replenish the soul.

If you are nearing the end of a long race and feeling the temptation to coast, you will be reminded why the final stretch matters most and how to finish with faithfulness intact.

The One who called you is faithful. He does not begin a work and abandon it. And He invites you—commands you—to follow His example: to start strong, to stay strong, and to finish strong.

Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us.

## Chapter 2: Count the Cost

Every meaningful life is shaped by intention. We do not drift into faithfulness, wholeness, or legacy. We move toward them by first seeing the end clearly—and then choosing, often daily, to pay the price required to get there.

Jesus understood this. That's why He consistently called people not merely to belief, but to counted commitment.

### Jesus and the Wisdom of Counting the Cost

Jesus invited His listeners to consider two very ordinary scenarios—building and warfare—because both require foresight.

*For which of you, desiring to build a tower, doesn't first sit down and count the cost, to see if he has enough to complete it? Lest perhaps, when he has laid a foundation, and is not able to finish, everyone who sees begins to mock him. —Luke 14:28–29 (WEB)*

Then He turns to war:

*Or what king, as he goes to encounter another king in war, will not sit down first and consider whether he is able with ten thousand to meet him who comes against him with twenty thousand? —Luke 14:31 (WEB)*

These are not lessons about architecture or armies. They are about discipleship.

Jesus closes with clarity that leaves little room for negotiation:

*So therefore whoever of you who doesn't renounce all that he has, he can't be my disciple. —Luke 14:33 (WEB)*

The cost is real. Jesus never minimizes it. But He also never suggests the cost is wasted.

## The Stakes of Not Counting the Cost

Many people never count the cost of victory. They set out with good intentions but without the preparation required to see it through. They want the promise, but they underestimate the pressure that comes with pursuing it. And when the resistance comes—and it always comes—they are overwhelmed.

The stakes of underpreparing are not abstract. History makes them vivid.

## Dieppe, 1942: The Cost of Unpreparedness

Two years before D-Day, the Allies attempted an amphibious assault on the French coast at Dieppe. It became one of the darkest chapters of the war.

On August 19, 1942, over 6,000 soldiers—predominantly Canadian—launched Operation Jubilee against the German-occupied port. The operation was plagued from the start: inadequate intelligence, insufficient naval and air support, a flawed assumption that they could seize a fortified port by frontal assault, and a loss of surprise when the convoy encountered a German patrol in the darkness before dawn.

In just nine hours, the raid was over. Over 900 Canadian soldiers were killed, 2,460 wounded, and nearly 2,000 taken prisoner. Tanks became trapped on the shingle beach. Men were pinned down by withering fire from cliffs they had underestimated. One historian called it "an object lesson on how not to mount an amphibious assault." Another described it simply as "an unmitigated disaster."

The goal was the same as it would be two years later: land on occupied France. The forces were capable. The courage was real. But the cost had not been counted. The preparation had not been done. And thousands paid the price.

## Normandy, 1944: The Cost Counted, the Victory Won

The Allies did not repeat the mistake. When they returned to the coast of France two years later, they came having counted the cost.

D-Day was the culmination of two full years of meticulous preparation—shaped in part by the blood-bought lessons of Dieppe. Over one million soldiers were shipped to the United Kingdom, equipped, trained, and fed before a single boot touched French sand. Planners analyzed tides, terrain, and German fortifications. They coordinated logistics across continents. They conducted extensive amphibious training exercises. They built artificial harbors to be towed across the Channel. They studied meteorological records, tidal patterns, and lunar cycles to identify the narrow windows when invasion was possible.

On June 6, 1944, over 7,000 naval vessels crossed the English Channel. Nearly 160,000 Allied troops landed that single day. The outcome was far from certain—General Eisenhower prepared two statements before giving the order, one announcing success, the other accepting full responsibility for failure. But the preparation held. The cost had been counted. And the invasion succeeded.

Same war. Same forces. Same goal. Radically different outcomes—because one operation rushed forward without counting the cost, and the other prepared relentlessly to finish what it started.

Scripture affirms this principle:

*For by wise guidance you will wage your war, and in the abundance of counselors there is victory. —Proverbs 24:6*  
(WEB)

Spiritually, many don't fall away because they rejected God, but because they were unprepared for the resistance that comes with obedience.

## When the Tower Stood Unfinished: The Ryugyong Hotel

Jesus warned that the man who lays a foundation without counting the cost becomes a mockery. History offers a sobering illustration.

In 1987, North Korea began constructing the Ryugyong Hotel in Pyongyang—a 105-story pyramid-shaped tower intended to be the tallest hotel in the world, completed in time for the 80th birthday of Kim Il Sung in 1992. The project consumed an estimated 2% of North Korea's GDP.

Then the Soviet Union collapsed. Funding evaporated. Construction halted in 1992 with the building topped out but entirely unfinished—no windows, no fixtures, no interior. For over a decade, a massive concrete shell loomed over the capital, a rusting crane still perched at the top.

When asked why it was never completed, a North Korean official gave a strikingly simple answer: "Because we ran out of money."

The BBC called it "a reminder of the totalitarian state's thwarted ambition." Some engineers who later inspected the structure concluded it was structurally irreparable. Decades later, LED screens now cover parts of the facade—broadcasting propaganda over a building that remains hollow inside.

The foundation was laid. The tower was never finished. And everyone who sees it knows.

## Building What Lasts: The Empire State Building

The contrast with the Empire State Building could not be sharper.

Rising 1,250 feet into the Manhattan skyline, it was completed during the darkest days of the Great Depression—in just 410 days of construction, ahead of schedule and under budget.

How was such speed possible? Extraordinary preparation.

The builders employed what we'd now call "fast-track" methods. They began foundation work before demolition of the previous building was complete. They designed lower floors while upper floors were still being finalized. At peak construction, 3,400 workers manned the site daily, achieving four and a half stories per week.

Every logistical detail was planned—miniature railroad tracks moved materials inside the building, cafeterias were set up on five different floors so workers wouldn't waste time descending to street level.

The builders knew the end before the foundation was laid. They counted the cost, prepared relentlessly, and finished what they started—during the worst economic crisis in American history. Nearly a century later, it still stands.

*Through wisdom a house is built; by understanding it is established.* —Proverbs 24:3 (WEB)

Lives collapse not because of weak intentions, but because of weak foundations.

## Why This Matters: You Are in a Battle and Building a Life

Jesus didn't tell these parables to discourage us from following Him. He told them so we would follow Him well—with eyes open, resolve firm, and foundations deep.

We are not drifting through neutral territory. We are walking out a spiritual battle, and the enemy opposes every step toward faithfulness. Scripture is clear:

*For our wrestling is not against flesh and blood, but against the principalities, against the powers, against the*

*world's rulers of the darkness of this age, and against the spiritual forces of wickedness in the heavenly places.*

—Ephesians 6:12 (WEB)

The king who didn't count his soldiers lost the war. The builder who didn't count the cost became a mockery. But the one who prepared—who understood what was required and resolved to pay it—stood firm when the test came.

As you consider the race before you, ask yourself honestly:

What will finishing well actually require? Not what you hope. What it demands—in time, discipline, sacrifice, and endurance.

Have you prepared for opposition? The enemy doesn't wait for you to feel ready. Are you building with materials that will hold?

What foundations still need to be laid? The Empire State Building rose quickly because the groundwork was done first. What groundwork have you neglected?

Scripture urges us to live with awareness of the end:

*So teach us to count our days, that we may gain a heart of wisdom.* —Psalm 90:12 (WEB)

The question isn't whether following Christ costs something. It does. The question is whether you've counted that cost and

resolved—not flippantly, but thoughtfully—to pay it so you can finish what you've begun.

That kind of life doesn't start later. It starts now, by beginning with the end clearly in mind.



# Chapter 3: Sell All for the Unseen

Some things only reveal their true value with time.

Jesus understood this. That's why His most striking parables about the Kingdom compare it to something whose worth is not immediately visible—treasure buried in a field, a pearl recognized only by the one who knew what to look for.

The cost of following Christ isn't hidden. But the reward often is. And that's precisely the point.

## The Kingdom as Hidden Treasure

Jesus describes the Kingdom of God in images that subvert our expectations:

*The Kingdom of Heaven is like treasure hidden in the field, which a man found and hid. In his joy, he goes and sells all that he has, and buys that field. —Matthew 13:44 (WEB)*

And again:

*The Kingdom of Heaven is like a merchant seeking fine pearls, who, having found one pearl of great price, went and sold all that he had, and bought it. —Matthew 13:45–46 (WEB)*

Notice what both parables share: the treasure required everything. The man sold all he had. The merchant liquidated his entire inventory. From the outside, this looks like recklessness—or loss.

But notice what else they share: joy.

The man who found the treasure didn't grieve as he signed over his possessions. He moved *in his joy*. He had found something worth more than all he possessed. The merchant wasn't suppressing his desires—he was finally satisfying them.

This is the great inversion of the Kingdom. We imagine that following Christ means settling for less, giving up what we truly want. But Jesus insists the opposite is true. The one who sees the treasure clearly doesn't experience surrender as loss. He experiences it as the only sane response.

## A Stone Wrapped in Paper

Imagine this scenario.

You're at an obscure auction in the mid-1600s, just after the English Civil War. The Crown Jewels have been seized, stripped of meaning, and sold off piece by piece. No ceremony. No fanfare. Just inventory.

One item catches your eye.

It's listed simply as: "A pierced balas ruby, wrapped in paper."

No story. No crown. No pedigree.

The price? About \$1,000 in today's money.

But to buy it, you have to sell everything. Your furniture. Your extra clothes. Your savings. Your sense of security.

People watch you liquidate your life for a stone wrapped in paper. They shake their heads. They whisper. They call you reckless... irresponsible... foolish.

"Why would you give up everything for *that*?"

But you do it anyway. Because you see something they don't.

Years pass. Then decades. Then centuries.

And history vindicates you.

# The Stone That History Forgot—Then Remembered

The gem's journey spans centuries of war, betrayal, and upheaval.

Historians begin to trace the stone's story. They discover it once belonged to a murdered Moorish prince in fourteenth-century Spain. Abu Said, the ruler of Granada, was invited to a peace negotiation by Pedro the Cruel of Castile—and stabbed to death upon arrival. Pedro seized his jewels, including the massive red stone.

The gem passed next to Edward the Black Prince, the heir to the English throne, as payment for military aid during the Castilian civil war. It became part of the English Crown Jewels.

King Henry V wore it mounted on his battle helmet at Agincourt, where a blow from a French blade struck his head with enough force to kill him—but the helmet held, and the stone survived. Richard III carried it into his final battle at Bosworth Field, where he lost his crown and his life.

Then came the English Civil War.

After the execution of Charles I in 1649, the Commonwealth government ordered the Crown Jewels inventoried and sold. This was not a misunderstanding of value—it was a deliberate rejection of meaning. Royal treasures were stripped of identity and reduced to raw commodities.

In the surviving records appears an entry for "a pierced balas ruby wrapped in paper by itself," sold for £4. Some historians believe this may refer to the very stone that had adorned the helmets of kings. If so, a treasure of immense historical significance was treated as an anonymous gem and sold for pocket change.

Then comes the reappraisal.

Scholars realize the stone isn't even technically a ruby. It's a red spinel—and not a small one. It weighs about 170 carats, making it the largest uncut red spinel of its kind in the world.

To understand what that means, consider this: In 2015, a 50-carat red spinel called the Hope Spinel sold at auction for \$1.5 million—roughly \$30,000 per carat.

At that rate alone—before history, before royalty, before symbolism—this stone would be worth over \$5 million.

And yet historians insist that number still misses the point.

In 1919, gemologist George Frederick Younghusband wrote: "The question is often asked, 'What is the value of this stone?' And the answer may safely be given that it is priceless, for no amount of money can buy it."

What once looked like a foolish purchase becomes one of the most brilliant investments imaginable.

Today, that stone is known as the Black Prince's Ruby. It sits at the very front of the British Imperial State Crown, surrounded by nearly 3,000 other jewels, the centerpiece of one of the most famous collections of regalia in the world.

The people who mocked your sacrifice are long gone. History remembers you differently.

Not as foolish. But as someone who recognized value before it was obvious.

## The Parallel to Jesus' Teaching

And this is where Jesus presses the question home.

What if the choices that look foolish right now—the obedience that costs you comfort, the generosity that feels excessive, the surrender that seems like loss—what if they are not losses at all?

That is exactly the logic of the parables.

The man who found the treasure hidden in the field didn't hesitate. He sold all that he had. The merchant who found the pearl of great price liquidated his entire inventory. From the outside, it looked like recklessness. From the inside, it was the only sane response—because they had seen the true value of what they were gaining.

If someone had recognized the Black Prince's Ruby in 1650, wrapped in paper and sold for pocket change, and had mortgaged

their home, sold their possessions, and borrowed from everyone they knew to purchase it—history would call them a genius.

Jesus says the Kingdom of God is like treasure hidden in a field. And when someone finds it, they sell everything—not with regret, but with joy.

Because one day, what looked like loss will be revealed as glory. What felt like foolishness will be named wisdom. And the sacrifices you make for the Kingdom are not disappearing—they are purchasing your future crown.

You are not throwing your life away. You are investing it.

And the return is beyond estimation.

## A Man Who Gave Everything for Earthly Treasure

If the logic of the parable still seems extreme, consider what men have done for treasures that will pass away.

In 1969, a former chicken farmer from Indiana named Mel Fisher moved to the Florida Keys with a single consuming goal: to find the *Nuestra Señora de Atocha*, a Spanish galleon that sank in a hurricane in 1622 carrying 40 tons of gold and silver, chests of emeralds, and riches almost beyond belief.

For sixteen years, Fisher searched. Day after day, he told his crew the same thing: "Today's the day." Most days, it wasn't.

The cost was staggering. Fisher worked for years without pay. He faced legal battles with the state and federal government that dragged on for nearly a decade. He lost investors. He lost credibility. And in 1975, he lost something no treasure could replace: his eldest son Dirk, his daughter-in-law Angel, and a diver named Rick Gage—all drowned when their salvage boat capsized.

Lesser men would have quit. Fisher kept searching.

On July 20, 1985—ten years to the day after his son's death—his son Kane radioed back to headquarters: "Put away the charts. We've found the Mother Lode."

The treasure recovered was valued at over \$400 million: stacks of silver bars, chests of coins, gold chains, emeralds from Colombian mines, and thousands of artifacts that had lain on the ocean floor for over three centuries.

Mel Fisher gave everything for that treasure—years, money, reputation, even family. And the world celebrated him for it.

But here is the question Jesus presses: If a man will sacrifice that much for gold that will corrode and silver that will tarnish, what will you give for a Kingdom that will never end?

Fisher pursued earthly treasure with total abandon. The merchant in Jesus' parable pursued a pearl. The man in the field pursued hidden riches. All of them understood the same principle: when you find something of ultimate value, you trade everything else to possess it.

The difference is this: Fisher's treasure, however magnificent, will eventually pass away. The treasure Jesus offers is eternal.

## When We Want Too Little

Many hesitate at surrender—not because they lack belief, but because the cost feels too high.

*I don't want to give up this relationship. I don't want to surrender this lifestyle. I don't want to lose comfort, reputation, or control.*

But what if the problem is not that we want too much, but that we want too little?

C.S. Lewis captured this with stunning clarity:

"We are half-hearted creatures, fooling about with drink and sex and ambition when infinite joy is offered us, like an ignorant child who wants to go on making mud pies in a slum because he cannot imagine what is meant by the offer of a holiday at the sea. We are far too easily pleased."

The child making mud pies isn't wicked. He's simply ignorant. He has never seen the sea. He cannot imagine the salt air, the crashing waves, the endless horizon. And so when someone offers him a holiday at the coast, he looks down at his mud and thinks: *Why would I trade this?*

That is precisely how we treat eternal life.

We clutch our small comforts, our fleeting pleasures, our carefully managed reputations—and we call it sacrifice to let them go. But what if we aren't being asked to sacrifice at all? What if we're being asked to trade mud for the sea?

*Don't lay up treasures for yourselves on the earth... but lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven.* —Matthew 6:19–20 (WEB)

When we refuse eternal treasure, we are not choosing nothing—we are choosing something infinitely less.

## Selling All for What You Cannot Yet See

The merchant who found the pearl of great price had to make a decision before the full value of his purchase was realized. He couldn't prove to others that this pearl was worth everything. He simply knew.

That's the nature of Kingdom investment. Eternal life is not immediately apparent. Its value lies beyond the horizon of time. But to the one who truly sees it, surrender becomes joy, not loss.

In the previous chapter, we counted the cost. We looked soberly at what following Christ requires—the preparation, the sacrifice, the resistance we will face. That counting is essential. Jesus Himself commands it.

But counting the cost is not the end of the story. It is only half the equation.

The other half is seeing the treasure.

The builder who counts the cost but never builds has gained nothing. The king who assesses his army but never engages has won no victory. Counting is meant to lead somewhere—to a clear-eyed, wholehearted *yes*.

And that *yes*, when it comes, is not reluctant. It is joyful.

The man in the field didn't drag his feet to the closing table. He ran. The merchant didn't haggle over the price of the pearl. He paid it gladly. They had seen something worth more than everything they possessed, and the transaction felt like gain, not loss.

## The Double Meaning

There is one more layer to these parables that we must not miss.

Yes, we are called to be the ones who find the treasure and sell all to possess it. But there is another way to read the story.

Jesus is the one who left the riches of heaven to come down and purchase the treasure of His people. *We* are the pearl of great price. *We* are the treasure hidden in the field. He saw us, valued us beyond all calculation, and gave everything—His throne, His comfort, His very life—to make us His own. We are the joy set before Him.

He is the merchant who went searching for something precious. And when He found it, He held nothing back.

What's beautiful is that He didn't just obtain the reward for Himself. He obtained it and then said, "Follow me, and I will share it with you." The Bible tells us in Revelation that to the one who overcomes, Christ will grant to sit with Him on His throne, just as He overcame and sat down with His Father on His throne.

You don't get a second-rate inheritance. You get the first-rate inheritance—because you are joined to the King.

## Have You Seen the Treasure?

The question isn't whether the Kingdom costs everything. It does.

The question is whether you've seen the treasure clearly enough to sell all for it—even while it remains unseen to the world around you.

What are you holding onto that feels too precious to release? And what might you be forfeiting by refusing to let go?

The merchant didn't grieve his exchange. He had found something worth more than all he possessed.

So have you.

The cost has been counted. The treasure has been revealed. Now it's time to move toward it with joy.



## Chapter 4: Joy as Strength

We have learned to start strong—to count the cost and to see the treasure clearly enough to sell everything for it. But beginning well is only part of the story.

The real test is whether we can stay strong once the journey has begun.

And here is the secret Scripture reveals: the same joy that initiates surrender is the joy that sustains endurance. When we start strong, we stay strong—not by gritting our teeth through misery, but by discovering a joy that runs deeper than our circumstances.

### Joy in the Exchange

Consider again the merchant who found the pearl of great price.

*The Kingdom of Heaven is like a merchant seeking fine pearls, who having found one pearl of great price, went and sold all that he had, and bought it. —Matthew 13:45–46 (WEB)*

Notice what drives the merchant's surrender: he *found* something. The sale wasn't reluctant. It wasn't bitter. The text tells us plainly that when the man discovered hidden treasure, he went and sold all that he had *in his joy*.

This is not the language of loss. It is the language of exchange.

The journey of discipleship doesn't begin with deprivation—it begins with discovery. The merchant saw something so valuable that everything else paled in comparison. His "giving up" was actually a "getting." And that initial flash of joy—the recognition that the treasure is worth far more than the cost—becomes the fuel that sustains us through every mile of the journey ahead.

Joy in the exchange begins the journey. And joy in the journey sustains it.

## The Architecture of Spiritual Strength

Scripture consistently ties spiritual strength to joy. This is not incidental. It is architectural—built into the very structure of how God sustains His people.

Consider Paul's prayer for the Colossians:

*For this cause, we also, since the day we heard this, don't cease praying and making requests for you, that you may be filled with the knowledge of his will in all spiritual*

*wisdom and understanding, that you may walk worthily of the Lord, to please him in all respects, bearing fruit in every good work and increasing in the knowledge of God, strengthened with all power, according to the might of his glory, for all patience and perseverance with joy. —Colossians 1:9–11 (WEB)*

Notice the sequence: filled with knowledge, walking worthily, bearing fruit, increasing in knowledge of God—and then: “*strengthened with all power, according to the might of his glory, for all patience and perseverance with joy.*” (vs. 11)

Strength from God's glorious power is given for endurance. And endurance is wrapped in joy.

James echoes the same truth:

*Count it all joy, my brothers, when you fall into various temptations, knowing that the testing of your faith produces endurance. Let endurance have its perfect work, that you may be perfect and complete, lacking in nothing. —James 1:2–4 (WEB)*

The testing of faith produces endurance. Endurance produces maturity. And the entire process is to be received with joy—not because the trial is pleasant, but because the outcome is worth it.

Paul drives this home again in Ephesians:

*That he would grant you, according to the riches of his glory, that you may be strengthened with power through his Spirit in the inner person, that Christ may dwell in your hearts through faith, to the end that you, being rooted and grounded in love, may be strengthened to comprehend with all the saints what is the width and length and height and depth, and to know Christ's love which surpasses knowledge, that you may be filled with all the fullness of God. —Ephesians 3:16–19 (WEB)*

Strengthened in the inner person. Rooted in love. Filled with the fullness of God. This is not the grim endurance of the reluctant. It is the overflowing life of those who have glimpsed the width and length and height and depth of something too magnificent to abandon.

We are strengthened with might so that we may know love. And we are strengthened with might so that we may know joy.

## The Great Inversion

Here is one of the great paradoxes of the spiritual life: there is often an inverse relationship between natural comfort and supernatural joy.

The comfort we sacrifice for the sake of the gospel frequently becomes the seedbed of our deepest satisfaction. We give up one thing and gain another—but what we gain is incomparably greater.

Paul understood this:

*For our light affliction, which is for the moment, works for us more and more exceedingly an eternal weight of glory, while we don't look at the things which are seen, but at the things which are not seen. For the things which are seen are temporal, but the things which are not seen are eternal. —2 Corinthians 4:17–18*

(WEB)

Paul calls his afflictions "light" and "momentary"—but this is the same man who was beaten, shipwrecked, stoned, and left for dead. He wasn't minimizing his suffering. He was reframing it. He was comparing it to something so overwhelmingly glorious that even the worst trials of this life became, by comparison, featherweight.

This is not mathematical. It is mystical—but it is true.

Some of the greatest moments of joy and comfort from the Holy Spirit come during the most adverse seasons of trial and difficulty. The wells of living water run deepest when the surface of life is driest. God meets His people in ways they could never have anticipated, and the joy He provides transcends explanation.

We must not allow these sentiments to become trite or cliché. We must believe—by faith—that as we endure through hardship, God is able to supply joy. And we make Him our source.

# The Runner's High

There is a phenomenon known to distance runners called the "runner's high"—a state of euphoria that can emerge during or after sustained physical exertion. Scientists have discovered that the body releases natural chemicals during intense exercise, including endorphins and endocannabinoids, that produce feelings of calm, reduced anxiety, and even bliss.

But here is what makes the runner's high so instructive: it doesn't come immediately.

Research suggests that this euphoric state typically requires at least twenty to forty-five minutes of sustained, moderately intense running before it kicks in. New runners rarely experience it at all—their bodies haven't yet adapted to the sustained effort required. The runner must push through discomfort, fatigue, and even pain before the breakthrough comes.

As one study noted, new runners "barely, if ever, report any positive feeling when running, relating a rather painful experience instead." It is only through consistent practice and sustained effort that the runner breaks through to the reward.

The phenomenon becomes so potent that many who experience it describe running as genuinely addictive—not because of external rewards, but because the body itself begins to crave the experience of breakthrough.

I believe this physical reality reflects a deeper spiritual principle.

As we run with endurance the race set before us, God releases joy to sustain us—but not always immediately. There is often a threshold to cross. A certain amount of dryness in the place of prayer. A certain amount of faithfulness in Scripture reading before we stumble upon a verse that plunges us deep into the heart of God.

We must run long enough, and consistently enough, to break through.

## Fixing Your Eyes on the Reward

But how do we practically make God our source of joy in the midst of trial?

We do it by meditating on the truth of eternal things.

Paul's ability to call his afflictions "light and momentary" didn't come from denial. It came from perspective. He wasn't focused on the afflictions—he was focused on "the eternal weight of glory" those afflictions were producing.

When we begin with the end in mind, we continue with the end in mind. We keep before us the vision of what we're running toward. And the more richly we grasp that vision, the more fully we are filled with joy by the Holy Spirit's revelation and power.

This is the key: joy is not manufactured by willpower. It is drawn from a well. And that well is accessed through attention, through Scripture, through prayer, through keeping our eyes fixed on what is eternal rather than what is temporary.

*So teach us to count our days, that we may gain a heart of wisdom.* —Psalm 90:12 (WEB)

If I were to say in a simple way what I want to admonish you with in this chapter, it is this: if the secret of starting strong is beginning with the end in mind and counting the cost, the secret to staying strong is fixing your eyes on the reward so that daily you're producing joy in your heart as you think about the end result of your endurance.

You actually have to, in your spirit, see the finish line—and let the reward of crossing that finish line invigorate you when it feels like you can't go on.

## The Joy Set Before Him

We see this most clearly in how Jesus approached the cross.

*Therefore let's also, seeing we are surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses, lay aside every weight and the sin which so easily entangles us, and let's run with perseverance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the author and perfecter of faith, who for the joy that was*

*set before him endured the cross, despising its shame, and has sat down at the right hand of the throne of God.*

—Hebrews 12:1–2 (WEB)

Jesus endured the cross *for the joy set before Him*.

That is the paradigm for our lives. We begin with the end in mind—seeing the treasure, recognizing its worth. And then we stay strong by keeping that joy before us, by meditating on the eternal weight of glory, by drawing from the wells of living water through rhythms of communion with God.

The joy is not imaginary. It is not wishful thinking. It is the supernatural provision of the Holy Spirit, given to those who seek God with consistency and faith.

And the joy is sufficient. It is enough to sustain us through every trial, every temptation, every dry season, every dark garden.

## What Are You Looking At?

The difference between those who stay strong and those who fall away is often not a difference in circumstances. It is a difference in focus.

Two people face the same trial. One collapses into bitterness. The other emerges with deeper faith. What made the difference?

Often, it is simply this: one was looking at the trial. The other was looking through it—to what lay on the other side.

Paul tells us plainly: we do not lose heart because we are looking not at the things that are seen, but at the things that are unseen. The seen things are temporary. The unseen things are eternal.

When your eyes are fixed on the temporary, every setback feels like the end of the world. Every loss feels permanent. Every sacrifice feels like waste.

But when your eyes are fixed on the eternal, setbacks become setups. Losses become investments. Sacrifices become seeds planted for a harvest you will one day reap with joy.

The question is not whether you will face adversity. You will. The question is what you will be looking at when it comes.

## The Fuel for the Journey

Joy is not a luxury for the spiritually elite. It is fuel for the journey.

Without it, we burn out. We grow bitter. We give up. We become the kind of Christians who technically believe the right things but have lost the fire that once made those truths come alive.

With it, we can endure anything.

Paul and Silas sang hymns at midnight in a Philippian jail, their backs bleeding from the beating they had received. The early church rejoiced that they were counted worthy to suffer shame for the name of Jesus. Martyrs throughout history have gone to their deaths with songs on their lips and peace in their hearts.

This is not natural. It is supernatural. It is the fruit of a joy that does not depend on circumstances—because it is rooted in a reality that circumstances cannot touch.

You have access to that joy.

It is found in the presence of God. It is activated by faith. It is sustained by practice. And it is sufficient for whatever lies ahead.

## The Joy of the Lord Is Your Strength

Perhaps nowhere in Scripture is the connection between joy and strength made more explicit than in the book of Nehemiah.

The scene is Jerusalem. The exiles have returned from Babylon. The walls have been rebuilt. And now, for the first time in generations, the people gather to hear the Law of God read aloud.

Ezra the scribe stands on a wooden platform and opens the Book of the Law. He reads from early morning until midday, and the people listen with rapt attention. Levites move through the crowd, helping the people understand what is being read.

And as understanding dawns, something unexpected happens.

*For all the people wept, when they heard the words of the law. —Nehemiah 8:9 (WEB)*

They wept. Not tears of joy—tears of conviction. As they heard God's commands, they recognized how far short they had fallen. They saw their neglect. They felt the weight of their disobedience. Their hearts broke under the realization of all they had failed to do.

This is the natural response to revelation. When we truly see God's standard, we see our failure. When we hear His words clearly, we feel our distance from them. The people of Jerusalem stood in the rubble of their spiritual neglect and mourned.

But then Nehemiah speaks:

*Nehemiah, who was the governor, and Ezra the priest and scribe, and the Levites who taught the people, said to all the people, "Today is holy to Yahweh your God. Don't mourn, nor weep... Go your way. Eat the fat, drink the sweet, and send portions to him for whom nothing is prepared, for today is holy to our Lord. Don't be grieved, for the joy of Yahweh is your strength." —Nehemiah 8:9–10 (WEB)*

Do you see what Nehemiah is doing?

He is not dismissing their conviction. Their tears were appropriate. Their broken hearts were right. But he is redirecting their response. Instead of fasting in mourning, they are to feast with rejoicing. Instead of wallowing in grief over past failure, they are to celebrate that they now know the right thing to do.

The principle is profound: because their hearts were repentant, they could now rejoice. The sorrow had done its work. Conviction had come. And now joy—not guilt—would give them the strength to walk out their fresh commitment to obedience.

*So the Levites calmed all the people, saying, "Hold your peace, for today is holy. Don't be grieved." All the people went their way to eat and to drink, and to send portions, and to make great mirth, because they had understood the words that were declared to them. —Nehemiah 8:11–12 (WEB)*

They made great mirth. They celebrated. They feasted. Not because they had arrived, but because they finally knew the path. Not because they were perfect, but because they were forgiven and redirected.

This is the joy that produces strength.

Guilt says: "You failed. You'll never change. Why even try?"

Joy says: "You failed. You're forgiven. Now you know the way. Let's go."

Guilt paralyzes. Joy empowers.

The joy of the Lord is your strength—not because joy ignores your failures, but because joy flows from a God who forgives them and empowers you to move forward.

## An Invitation to Joy

If you are reading this and feel far from joy—if the race has worn you down and the finish line feels impossibly distant—I want you to know that the invitation still stands.

Perhaps, like the people in Nehemiah's day, you have recently been confronted with how far you've fallen short. Perhaps the Law has been read, and you feel the weight of your neglect and disobedience. Perhaps tears feel more appropriate than celebration.

Let those tears do their work. Let conviction break the hard ground of your heart.

But do not stay there.

Nehemiah's word to you is the same as it was to them: *Don't be grieved, for the joy of the Lord is your strength.*

Joy is not a reward for those who have already arrived. It is provision for those who are still on the way. It is not earned by perfection. It is received by those who have seen their failure, repented, and are now ready to walk forward in fresh obedience.

You do not have to manufacture it. You have to receive it.

And you receive it the same way the merchant received the pearl: by recognizing its value, by letting go of what you're clutching, and by opening your hands to take hold of what God is offering.

The joy set before you is real. The treasure is worth it. And the One who began a good work in you is faithful to complete it.

Now you know the way. So go—eat the fat, drink the sweet, and make great mirth.

For the joy of the Lord is your strength.



# Chapter 5: Rhythms of the Garden

Joy is not an accident. It is cultivated.

In the previous chapter, we saw that joy is the fuel for endurance—that the same delight which initiates surrender is the delight that sustains us through the messy middle. But joy does not fall on us randomly like rain. It is drawn from a well. And that well is accessed through rhythm, through practice, through repeated encounters with God that gradually deepen our capacity to receive what He is offering.

If Chapter 4 was about *why* joy matters, this chapter is about *how* joy is sustained.

## The Bible Is Deeper Than It Is Long

When we create rhythms of meditation and Scripture, we discover something remarkable: the Bible is far deeper than it is long.

Consider the shortest verse in Scripture:

*Jesus wept.* —John 11:35

Two words. Yet within those two words lies an ocean of revelation about how God meets us in our places of suffering.

The Son of God—who knew He was about to raise Lazarus from the dead—wept anyway. He entered fully into human grief. He did not hold Himself aloof from sorrow. He did not rush past the pain to get to the miracle. He stood at the grave of His friend and He wept.

Meditate on that verse for an hour, and you will not exhaust its depth.

This is what I mean when I say the Bible is deeper than it is long. You can read it quickly and skim the surface, or you can linger over even the smallest passages and find pools of revelation that plunge far deeper than they appear.

It's like walking through a garden and suddenly discovering a spring—a place where the water runs deep and clear, where you can dive in and find yourself surrounded by the presence of God. The garden is full of such places. But you have to walk slowly enough to find them.

## Walking in the Garden

There is an ancient image woven into the opening pages of Scripture: God walking in the garden in the cool of the day.

*They heard Yahweh God's voice walking in the garden in the cool of the day, and the man and his wife hid themselves from the presence of Yahweh God among the trees of the garden. —Genesis 3:8 (WEB)*

The Hebrew verb for "walking" often implies habitual or repetitive movement—a regular practice, a customary rhythm. Many scholars believe this suggests that God's presence in the garden was not a one-time event but a pattern—a daily communion that Adam and Eve had come to expect and recognize.

When they heard Him coming, they knew the sound. They had walked with Him before.

What changed after the Fall was not that God stopped coming—but that humanity hid.

The invitation has never been rescinded. God still desires to walk with His people. The question is whether we will meet Him there.

Eden was the first sanctuary—the place where heaven and earth met, where humanity walked with the Divine in the cool of the day. That communion was disrupted by sin, but it has been restored in Christ. And now the question comes to each of us: Where is it that you get to rhythmically join with God in the garden?

# The Garden of Gethsemane

We must not imagine that walking with God means walking only in pleasant places.

Jesus met His Father in the Garden of Gethsemane during the darkest night of His earthly life. He was "greatly distressed and troubled." He told His disciples, "My soul is exceedingly sorrowful, even to death." He fell to the ground and prayed that the hour might pass from Him.

*He said, "Abba, Father, all things are possible to you. Please remove this cup from me. However, not what I desire, but what you desire."* —Mark 14:36 (WEB)

And yet—He met God there. He drew strength there. An angel came and strengthened Him. And when He rose from prayer, He was ready to walk the road to Calvary.

The garden was not a place of escape. It was a place of encounter.

Sometimes our rhythms of meeting with God will carry us through seasons of joy. Other times, they will carry us through seasons of anguish. But the rhythm remains. The practice persists. And God meets us—in the light and in the darkness—with strength for the journey.

The writer of Hebrews tells us that Jesus, "for the joy that was set before him, endured the cross, despising its shame." Even in anguish,

joy sustained Him. The joy set before Him—the redemption of His people, the glory of the Father, the weight of eternal purpose—carried Him through.

Whether we draw on God in seasons of sorrow or in moments of delight, the question remains: How do we walk with Him rhythmically? What does it look like to meet Him regularly, in ways that give us strength for the journey?

## Creating Rhythms of Joy

Joy is drawn upon as we create rhythms that permit it.

Just as the runner must train consistently before the breakthrough comes, we must establish practices that create space for the Holy Spirit to fill us. Joy doesn't usually arrive in the absence of habit. It arrives through habit—through repeated encounters with God that gradually deepen our capacity to receive what He is offering.

This is not about religious performance. It's about intentional presence.

One simple practice I have adopted is a morning walk to the end of my driveway, during which I thank God for His blessings. It takes only a few minutes. But that daily rhythm—alongside my cup of coffee and my daily vitamins—has become an anchoring practice that draws me into gratitude and opens my heart to joy.

It is not complicated. It is not impressive. But it is consistent. And consistency is where the breakthrough lives.

## What Are Your Rhythms?

What are the rhythmic practices in your life that create space for fellowship with God?

They might be spiritual: daily Scripture reading, prayer walks, fasting, worship music, memorizing verses, journaling prayers.

They might be physical: exercise, being in nature, gardening, caring for your body in ways that honor God. The body and soul are more connected than we often realize, and physical rhythms can create openings for spiritual encounter.

They might be relational: meals with family, service to neighbors, regular gatherings with believing friends, accountability conversations, hospitality.

They might be reflective: journaling, reading, meditating on art or beauty, reviewing the day with gratitude, sitting in silence.

I want you to think beyond the narrow category of "religious activities" and ask: Where is God actively meeting me? Where do I sense His presence most readily? Where do I want to join Him?

The people of God were created for communion with their Creator. Eden was the first sanctuary—the place where heaven and earth met.

That communion was disrupted by sin, but it has been restored in Christ. The veil has been torn. Access has been granted. The garden is open again.

The question is whether we will show up.

## The Compound Effect

There is a principle in finance called compound interest—small, consistent investments that grow exponentially over time. A little, invested regularly, becomes a lot.

The same principle applies to spiritual rhythms.

A five-minute prayer each morning doesn't seem like much. A single chapter of Scripture doesn't feel transformative. A brief walk of gratitude appears insignificant.

But do it every day for a week, and you begin to notice something. Do it every day for a month, and the roots go deeper. Do it every day for a year, and you have built a reservoir of strength that can sustain you through storms you never saw coming.

The people who stay strong through crisis are rarely the ones who developed their spiritual disciplines during the crisis. They are the ones who had been quietly, faithfully, consistently meeting with God for years before the crisis came.

The well was already dug. The rhythm was already established. And when the drought came, they had a source to draw from.

## When the Rhythm Breaks

But what about when the rhythm breaks?

Life is unpredictable. Seasons change. Illness comes. Schedules shift. Children are born. Jobs are lost. Moves happen. And suddenly the rhythms that sustained us for years are disrupted.

This is not failure. This is life.

The goal is not perfection. The goal is return.

When you miss a day, come back the next. When you miss a week, come back the next. When you miss a month—or a year—come back today.

God is not keeping score. He is not tallying your failures. He is standing at the edge of the garden, in the cool of the day, waiting for you to stop hiding and come walk with Him again.

The rhythm matters. But the relationship matters more. And the relationship is always waiting to be resumed.

# Depth Over Speed

We live in an age of efficiency. We want quick results, instant transformation, microwave spirituality. We approach the Bible like a checklist: chapters to complete, verses to consume, boxes to tick.

But the spiritual life resists hurry.

There is a way of reading Scripture that skims the surface and gathers information. And there is a way of reading Scripture that plunges into the depths and encounters a Person.

The first way can be done quickly. The second way requires lingering.

I would rather you read one verse slowly, turning it over in your mind, letting it sink into your soul, than read ten chapters at speed and retain nothing.

I would rather you pray one honest sentence from the depths of your heart than recite a thousand words out of obligation.

I would rather you take one walk with genuine gratitude than perform an hour of religious activity with your mind elsewhere.

Depth over speed. Presence over performance. Encounter over efficiency.

This is how joy is cultivated.

# The Rhythm of Return

There is one more rhythm I want to highlight: the rhythm of return.

Throughout Scripture, God's people are called to return—to come back, to repent, to start again. The prophets are filled with this language. "Return to me," says the Lord, "and I will return to you."

This is not a one-time event. It is a pattern. A rhythm.

We drift. We return. We wander. We come back. We forget. We remember. We hide. We emerge.

And every time we return, God is there. Not angry. Not distant. Not keeping a record of how long we were gone. Simply there, ready to walk with us again.

The rhythm of return is built into the fabric of the spiritual life. It assumes failure. It anticipates wandering. And it promises that the way back is always open.

If you have drifted from the rhythms that once sustained you, today is the day of return. Not tomorrow. Not when you feel ready. Not when you've cleaned yourself up. Today.

The garden is waiting. The Father is walking. And He would love nothing more than for you to join Him.

## A Practical Invitation

Let me close this chapter with a practical invitation.

In the next week, I want you to establish—or re-establish—one simple rhythm of meeting with God.

Just one.

It might be a morning prayer. It might be an evening review of the day. It might be a walk of gratitude. It might be five minutes of Scripture before bed. It might be silence in your car before you walk into work.

Choose something sustainable. Something you can actually do, not something that sounds impressive but will collapse under the weight of real life.

And then do it. Every day. For one week.

Don't worry about feelings. Don't wait for the breakthrough. Just show up.

The runner's high doesn't come on the first day. The well doesn't fill with a single rain. The compound interest doesn't multiply overnight.

But it does come. It does fill. It does multiply.

Joy is cultivated through rhythm. And the rhythm starts with a single step.

Take it today.

## Chapter 6: The Final Stretch

We began this journey by learning to start strong—counting the cost, seeing the treasure, and resolving to pay the price. We continued by exploring how to stay strong—discovering that joy is the fuel for endurance and that rhythms of communion with God sustain us through the messy middle.

Now we come to the question that gives meaning to everything that came before:

Will we finish what we started?

### The Three Movements

Every life of faithfulness follows a pattern. It is not a formula—life is too complex for that—but it is a recognizable shape, visible across Scripture and throughout history.

*Start Strong*—Beginning with the end in mind. Counting the cost. Recognizing the treasure and choosing to pay the price.

*Stay Strong*—Establishing rhythms and practices. Returning to the well. Finding joy in the journey, even when the road is hard.

*Finish Strong*—Completing what God has entrusted to us. Digging deep when the race is nearly done. Crossing the line with faithfulness intact.

Starting well matters. Sustaining well matters. But finishing well often determines how the entire journey is remembered.

In life, in leadership, in calling, and in faith—completion carries weight.

The question is not only: Did I begin with faith?

It is: Did I complete what God asked me to carry?

## Why Finishing Is Harder Than Starting

Here is a truth that surprises many who are new to the faith: maturity brings greater weight, not less.

As we grow spiritually, the stakes increase. More responsibility. More influence. More consequences. With maturity comes pressure—not the absence of it.

This is counterintuitive. We imagine that growth should produce ease, that experience should make the burden lighter. And in some ways, it does—we develop skills, wisdom, and spiritual resilience. But in other ways, the load increases. We are entrusted with more. We are watched by more eyes. Our choices carry greater consequences.

And here is the subtle danger: success early on can create false permission later.

The voice whispers: "I've earned this." Or: "I've already done enough." Or: "I can ease up now."

Past faithfulness becomes the justification for present compromise. The very victories God gave us become the foundation for pride—and pride precedes a fall.

Scripture consistently shows that temptation intensifies near fulfillment. The enemy rarely attacks beginnings as fiercely as he attacks finishes. He knows that an unfinished work, a collapsed ending, a final compromise—these can undo in a moment what took decades to build.

Many people start well. Fewer sustain well. Even fewer finish well.

Completion requires endurance. It requires resolve. It requires focus under fatigue—the capacity to keep moving when every part of you wants to stop.

## Six Agonizing Minutes

On August 5, 1984, the first-ever women's Olympic marathon was held in Los Angeles. It was a historic moment—a milestone for women's athletics. Joan Benoit of the United States won gold, crossing the finish line with a time of 2:24:52.

But twenty minutes later, another runner entered the stadium—and the world watched in stunned silence.

Gabriela Andersen-Schiess of Switzerland had missed the final water station under the brutal California sun. She entered the Los Angeles Coliseum in a state of severe heat exhaustion. Her torso was twisted. Her left arm hung limp. Her legs barely responded to her will. She staggered onto the track for the final 400 meters—and the crowd gasped.

Medical personnel rushed toward her. She waved them away. She knew that if they touched her, she would be disqualified.

For nearly six agonizing minutes, the entire stadium watched as she stumbled around the track, swaying, stopping, nearly collapsing—but refusing to quit. The crowd roared. They cheered her around every excruciating meter. And when she finally crossed the finish line in 37th place, she collapsed into the arms of race officials.

Her time of 2:48:42 was irrelevant. What mattered was that she finished.

She won no medal that day—but she won something far more enduring. Her image became an instant symbol of what it means to dig deep when everything in you wants to stop.

When asked years later about that agonizing final lap, she said simply: "You give everything you have."

This is the reality of the final stretch. In races, it is often where runners collapse. In life, it is often where faithfulness fractures. Ninety percent excellence means nothing if the final play fails. An unfinished initiative, a fractured ending, a compromised conclusion—these often shape how the entire story is remembered.

Finishing does not erase the struggle. It redeems it.

## Scripture's Call to Finish

The Apostle Paul understood this. Writing near the end of his life, imprisoned in Rome, aware that his death was near, he penned these words to Timothy:

*“I have fought the good fight. I have finished the race. I have kept the faith. From now on, the crown of righteousness is stored up for me, which the Lord, the righteous judge, will give to me on that day; and not to me only, but also to all those who have loved his appearing.”* —2 Timothy 4:7–8 (WEB)

Notice what Paul does not say. He does not boast in how he started—though his conversion was dramatic. He does not boast in his revelations, his miracles, his churches planted, or his letters written. He anchors his confidence in how he finished.

*“I have fought the good fight.”* Not “I entered the arena.”

*“I have finished the race.”* Not “I ran well for a season.”

*"I have kept the faith."* Not "I once believed."

The verbs are all perfect tense—completed action with enduring results. Paul is not merely looking back at past accomplishments; he is declaring that the work remains intact. The race is done. The faith is preserved. The crown is waiting.

This is the testimony every believer should long for: not perfection, but completion. Not ease, but faithfulness to the end.

## Run to Win

Scripture is saturated with the imagery of endurance and completion.

Paul writes to the Corinthians:

*Don't you know that those who run in a race all run, but one receives the prize? Run like that, so that you may win. Every man who strives in the games exercises self-control in all things. Now they do it to receive a corruptible crown, but we an incorruptible. I therefore run like that, not aimlessly. I fight like that, not beating the air. —1 Corinthians 9:24–26 (WEB)*

He writes to the Philippians:

*Brothers, I don't regard myself as yet having taken hold, but one thing I do: forgetting the things which are behind*

*and stretching forward to the things which are before, I press on toward the goal for the prize of the high calling of God in Christ Jesus. —Philippians 3:13–14 (WEB)*

And the writer of Hebrews exhorts:

*Therefore let's also, seeing we are surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses, lay aside every weight and the sin which so easily entangles us, and let's run with perseverance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the author and perfecter of faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising its shame, and has sat down at the right hand of the throne of God.*  
—Hebrews 12:1–2 (WEB)

The consistent testimony of Scripture is this: God is not only the author of our faith—He is its finisher. He does not begin a work and abandon it. And He calls us to the same pattern: to complete what we have been given, not merely to start it.

## The Temptation to Coast

The temptation at the end is not usually dramatic rebellion. It is something quieter. More subtle. More respectable.

It is the temptation to coast.

To ease up. To let someone else carry the load. To tell yourself you've done enough, served enough, sacrificed enough. To shift from active engagement to passive presence. To stop running and start gliding.

The logic sounds reasonable: "I've been faithful for decades. Surely I can relax now. Surely I've earned a break."

But the final miles are not the place for coasting. They are the place for digging deep.

Consider how many leaders have fallen in their final seasons. How many marriages have collapsed after the children left. How many ministries have ended in scandal after years of fruitful service. How many believers have drifted into compromise in their later years, trading the convictions of their youth for the comforts of their age.

The enemy is patient. He will wait decades for the right moment. And that moment is often at the end, when guards are down and finish lines are in sight.

This is why Paul, even as he approached his death, was still fighting. Still running. Still keeping the faith. He had not shifted into cruise control. He was pressing on until the very end.

## What Finishing Requires

So what does it actually take to finish strong?

First, recognize that the cost at the end is often higher.

The final stretch requires more humility, not less. More dependence, not more independence. More prayer, not more self-reliance. Finishing well is rarely accidental. It is the fruit of intentional, sustained faithfulness—especially when no one is watching.

Second, return to what got you started.

When strength fades, go back to first love. First practices. First obedience. The disciplines that sustained you at the beginning are the ones that will carry you home. Do not despise the simple things: prayer, Scripture, community, worship, confession. They are not beneath you. They are the ground beneath your feet.

Third, choose faithfulness over relief.

Finishing strong often means saying no when it would be easier to say yes. It means staying steady when recognition fades. It means obeying when outcomes are uncertain. Relief is not wrong—but relief is not the goal. Faithfulness is.

The same rhythms we explored in the previous chapter—the practices that sustain joy—become even more critical in the final stretch. When the race is nearly done, we do not abandon the well. We draw from it more deeply than ever.

## The Summit Was Only Halfway

I mentioned in the first chapter that when Caleb and I reached the summit of Mount Kenya, we were ecstatic. We had made it. We stood at the top.

But I left out one detail.

The summit was only halfway.

We had to go up, and then we had to go all the way back down. The same terrain we had climbed in the darkness, we now had to descend in daylight—exhausted, depleted, altitude-sick. The victory of reaching the peak did not exempt us from the journey home.

And honestly? The descent was harder than the climb.

Going up, we had adrenaline. We had anticipation. We had the summit pulling us forward. Going down, we had only the memory of the peak and the long road still ahead. Our legs ached. Our lungs burned. Our guide was still vomiting. And the finish line—the base camp where we had started—felt impossibly far away.

Many spiritual journeys are like this. The dramatic moment of breakthrough—the conversion, the calling, the consecration—is not the end. It is the midpoint. And the road home requires just as much endurance as the road up.

The question is not only whether you can reach the summit. It is whether you can make it all the way back.

## Leaving It All on the Field

Gabriela Andersen-Schiess did not win a medal in Los Angeles. But she won something more enduring: a legacy of perseverance that has inspired millions for four decades.

When she said, "You give everything you have," she was articulating the posture of everyone who finishes strong. Not perfection. Not ease. But everything given. Nothing held back.

Paul did not claim a flawless life. He claimed a completed one. And that is the testimony God is after—not the absence of failure, but the presence of faithfulness to the end.

*I have fought the good fight. I have finished the race. I have kept the faith.*

That is the goal. That is the prize. That is what we are running toward.

## A Charge for the Final Stretch

Whatever you are carrying today—a calling, a relationship, a season, a vision—do not taper off. Do not disengage. Do not let the

weariness of the final stretch convince you that the finish line doesn't matter.

It matters.

The way you finish will echo beyond the moment. It will shape the legacy you leave. It will determine whether the race was worth running.

So dig deep. Return to surrender. Draw from the well one more time. And finish the race.

God honors beginnings. God sustains rhythms. But God delights in faithfulness to the end.

# Chapter 7: It Is Finished

If we want to understand what it means to finish strong, we must look to Jesus.

His ministry was filled with power, favor, and fruit. Crowds followed Him. The sick were healed. The dead were raised. The kingdom was proclaimed. By any measure, His public years were an extraordinary success.

But the hardest obedience came at the end.

And it is there—in the final hours, in the garden and on the cross—that we see most clearly what it means to complete what you started.

## The Garden Before the Cross

Jesus went to a garden on the night of His betrayal—the Garden of Gethsemane, on the Mount of Olives, a place He had visited many times before.

But this night was different.

The Gospels tell us He was "greatly distressed and troubled." He told His disciples, "My soul is exceedingly sorrowful, even to death." He fell to the ground and prayed that the cup might pass from Him.

*He went forward a little, and fell on the ground, and prayed that if it were possible, the hour might pass from him. He said, "Abba, Father, all things are possible to you. Please remove this cup from me. However, not what I desire, but what you desire." —Mark 14:35–36 (WEB)*

This was not theater. This was agony.

Jesus did not bypass the struggle—He surrendered within it. He did not pretend the cup was easy to drink. He asked for it to be removed. He sweat drops like blood under the weight of what lay ahead.

And yet, even in that anguish, He prayed the words that would carry Him to the cross: "Not what I desire, but what you desire."

Luke tells us that an angel appeared and strengthened Him. And when He rose from prayer, He was ready. Ready to face the betrayal. Ready to endure the trials. Ready to walk the road to Calvary.

The garden was not a place of escape. It was a place of encounter—with the Father, with the weight of His mission, with the cost of completion. And Jesus emerged resolved.

He had set His face toward the finish line. And nothing would turn Him back.

## The Road to Calvary

What followed was a cascade of suffering.

Betrayal by a friend. Abandonment by His closest disciples. A sham trial in the middle of the night. False accusations. Mockery. Beatings. The crowd choosing a murderer over Him.

Then came the scourging—a Roman punishment so severe that many did not survive it. Leather straps embedded with bone and metal, tearing flesh with every stroke. By the time they were finished, Jesus was barely recognizable.

They pressed a crown of thorns into His scalp. They dressed Him in a purple robe and bowed in mock worship. They spit on Him. They struck Him. They laughed.

And then they led Him out to be crucified.

He carried His own cross until He could carry it no longer. Simon of Cyrene was pressed into service to bear it the rest of the way. They brought Him to Golgotha—the Place of the Skull—and there they nailed Him to the wood.

For six hours, He hung between heaven and earth. The weight of His body pulling against the nails. Every breath a struggle. The sun beating down, then darkness covering the land.

And through it all, He did not quit. He did not call down legions of angels. He did not save Himself, though He had the power to do so.

He had come to finish what He started. And He would see it through to the end.

## Tetelestai

On that cross, after hours of suffering, Jesus spoke a single Greek word that echoes through history:

*Tetelestai.*

*When Jesus therefore had received the vinegar, he said, "It is finished!" Then he bowed his head and gave up his spirit. —John 19:30 (WEB)*

*Tetelestai* comes from the verb *teleō*, meaning "to bring to an end, to complete, to accomplish." In the perfect tense, it signifies a completed action with ongoing results—something finished in the past that remains finished forever.

Jesus did not say, "I am finished"—as though He had been defeated.

He declared, "It is finished"—as though He had conquered.

The mission was complete. The debt was paid. The work the Father had given Him was accomplished. Every prophecy fulfilled. Every requirement satisfied. Every sin atoned for.

In that single word, the entire story of redemption reached its climax. What began in a garden with a serpent and a lie was completed on a cross with a Savior and the truth.

It is finished.

Not "it is almost done." Not "it is mostly complete." Not "it will be finished someday."

*Tetelestai.* It is finished. Once and for all. Forever.

## The Ultimate Picture of Finishing Strong

This is the ultimate picture of finishing strong.

Jesus did not coast to the end. He did not delegate the hardest part. He did not compromise at the final hour. He endured the cross—despising its shame—for the joy that was set before Him.

And what was that joy?

It was you.

It was the redemption of His people. The reconciliation of sinners to God. The defeat of death and the destruction of the devil's work.

The joy of presenting a spotless bride to His Father. The joy of hearing "Well done" and sitting down at the right hand of the throne of God.

For that joy, He endured everything.

And now He invites us to do the same.

## He Finished So You Could Finish

Here is the good news that makes everything else possible: Jesus finished so that you could finish.

You are not running this race alone. You are not summoning strength from your own reserves. You are not white-knuckling your way to the finish line on sheer willpower.

The One who began a good work in you is faithful to complete it.

*Being confident of this very thing, that he who began a good work in you will complete it until the day of Jesus Christ.* —Philippians 1:6 (WEB)

He is the author *and the finisher* of your faith. He started the work. He sustains the work. And He will bring it to completion.

This does not mean you are passive. You still run. You still fight. You still press on. But you do it in His strength, not your own. You do it

with His Spirit, not merely your determination. You do it because He first did it for you.

The cross is not just an example to follow. It is a power to receive.

Jesus did not merely show you how to finish strong. He made it possible for you to finish strong. His finished work is the foundation on which your perseverance stands.

## The Same Pattern

Jesus is the prototype. We are called to follow.

*Looking to Jesus, the author and perfecter of faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising its shame, and has sat down at the right hand of the throne of God. For consider him who has endured such contradiction of sinners against himself, that you don't grow weary, fainting in your souls. —Hebrews 12:2–3 (WEB)*

When you are tempted to grow weary, consider Him.

When you are tempted to faint in your soul, consider Him.

When the final stretch feels impossible, when the cost feels too high, when the finish line feels too far—consider Him.

He faced the contradiction of sinners. He endured the shame. He drank the cup to its dregs. And He sat down at the right hand of the throne of God.

That is where the race leads. That is what the finish line looks like. And that is the inheritance waiting for everyone who endures to the end.

## A Life Well Lived

We have walked through three movements of a faithful life.

*Start Strong*—by beginning with the end in mind. See the treasure. Count the cost. Embrace the joy of the exchange. Resolve in your heart that you are going all the way to the top, and let that resolution carry you through the resistance you will face.

*Stay Strong*—by returning to rhythm and practice. Draw from the wells of living water. Cultivate joy through communion with God. Fix your eyes on the reward so that daily you are producing strength in your heart as you think about the end result of your endurance.

*Finish Strong*—by digging deep, returning to surrender, and completing the race. Give everything. Hold nothing back. And when you are tempted to coast, remember that the final stretch is where faithfulness is most tested and most rewarded.

A life well lived is not measured only by how it begins, but by how faithfully it is brought to completion.

# The Promise

And here is the promise that anchors everything:

The One who began a good work in you is faithful to complete it.

You will face trials. You will encounter resistance. You will have seasons of dryness and moments of doubt. You will be tempted to quit, to coast, to settle for less than what God has called you to.

But you do not face any of it alone.

The same Jesus who said *Tetelestai* over His own mission is speaking that same word over yours. He is committed to your completion. He is working in you both to will and to do His good pleasure. He will not abandon the work of His hands.

Your job is to keep running. To keep returning. To keep your eyes fixed on Him.

And one day—one glorious, unimaginable day—you will cross the finish line. You will stand before the One who called you, redeemed you, and sustained you. And you will hear the words that every faithful servant longs to hear:

*"Well done, good and faithful servant. Enter into the joy of your Master."*

That is the end we are running toward. That is the joy set before us.  
That is what makes every sacrifice worth it and every struggle  
meaningful.

## A Final Charge

Wherever you are today—at the starting line, in the messy middle, or  
approaching the final stretch—I leave you with this charge:

Do not quit.

Do not coast.

Do not let the weariness of the moment rob you of the glory that  
awaits.

You have counted the cost. You have seen the treasure. You have  
tasted the joy that sustains endurance. You have established rhythms  
that draw you back to the well. And now you know what finishing  
requires.

The cloud of witnesses is watching. The Author and Finisher is with  
you. The crown of righteousness is stored up for all who love His  
appearing.

So run. Press on. Dig deep. And finish the race.

Start strong. Stay strong. Finish strong.

And one day, may we all hear the words:

*"Well done, good and faithful servant."*

It is finished.